Medea Redux

By Neil LaBute

WOMAN: **(Pg 75-94)** . . . can I just speak? 's that okay? I mean, I'll talk about, but . . . I got 'a sort of ease into it, you know? 'cause I was never, like, this major talker or anything . . . like to keep things to myself. Some people'd call it "private" or whatever, but it's more like just being sort'a "inward" right? I'm an inward kind 'a person . . .

INTRODUCTION

Medea by Euripides is a tale from Greek mythology which illustrates how the relentless pursuit of vengeance can be taken to its furthest extreme. In the story, Medea is driven by a passionate desire to right the wrongs done to her -- she sacrifices even her own children in the pursuit of revenge.

In this selection, Medea Redux by Neil LaBute, our tragic heroine tells a police investigator her tale of what she feels is ultimately revenge. But we are left to question whether her actions are those of vengeance or are driven by the damaged mind and soul of an abused 13-year-old, who once placed her unfailing trust in a teacher . . . a middle school teacher.

Medea by Neil LaBute

WOMAN: I think it depends a lot on the way you grow up, you know, family and all, and I just ended up more inward than anything . . . it's interesting, you know, how things'll work out. Well, not "out," I guess not so much that as maybe just "through" right? Things get worked through . . . or work themselves through. We probably don't have all that much to do with it. We like to think we do, though, right? God, like we're in on all the big planetary decisions you know? but, uh-uh . . . you wanna know what I feel, I think we're just spinning around out here, completely out 'a whack and no way of ever getting it right again, I mean, back on track or whatever . . . just can't do it. see, we been doing things wrong for so long now that it all starts to feel okay after a while, you know, like this is how it oughta be. *(beat)* there's a Greek word for that . . . I learned it in school. He taught it to me . . . well, I guess I more like "heard" it from him, if I'd 'a learned it I could tell you what it is, right? Yeah. I know it's Greek, though, I caught that much, but I don't remember what it was . . . *(thinks quietly)* no

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. . . 's too long ago now. Had something to do with the world, the whole thing, coming off its axis or something, going off in the wrong direction from how it's all supposed to be. And it's the fault of people. or "mortals," that's what my teacher said, "mortals are to blame." See, he said it was simply the fact that - and I never could understand this, maybe I just didn't listen good enough, that was the usual problem-but he said it all stemmed from just our being mortal. Right? *(beat)* So, then every problem we got is from being mortals. Explain me that . . .

You know a lot of times I just couldn't make clear what was coming out'a his mouth. He was really smart, though, had, like, two college degrees or something, and still wanted to work at public school. I kind 'a admired that. I was in his class, one of 'em, his first year. 's great . . . he took us, my class anyway, on a bunch 'a stuff, field trips, like museums, and up to Chicago one time. That was fun.

You know what's funny? He hit on me; my teacher did, on one of those trips. Yeah. . . scared me! I didn't even know what he was doing at first - I mean, okay, I did, but I was, like, thirteen - and that's just not what you're expecting at that age. Well, maybe it never is . . . he came up behind me at the observation tank, right, where they've got the sharks and everything . . . *(beat)* well, I'm keeping my eye on this one big hammerhead, and he's darting in real close to the glass, suddenly, I feel all this weight up against me. My teacher is pushing me forward with his body, up onto the observation windows, and I can't move. He never said anything while it was happening, I mean, to me - I could hear him whispering something about the "tragic nobility of sea creatures," some shit like that - and all I can see, I can't turn at all, the way he's got me held there, all I can see is this shark, the one I'd been watching, coming out of the murk and sweeping past me, again and again . . . He turns past the glass at the last second and his eye just sort'a rolls back all white as he passes . . . that was scary. I've never forgotten it. That feeling. His weight on me, and watching as that hammerhead just kept circling around... *(beat)* well, what the hell, it's easy to scare a kid. Right?

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Anyway, he wouldn't look at me after that, my teacher, not even a glance, the whole rest of the trip. And he was always real nice before, and funny to me . . . I mean, not in a bad way, not like inappropriately so, I don't think, but - no, I wasn't even a "teacher's pet" or whatever - he was just sort'a open with me. Jokes, and showing me pictures in magazines, like, we were starting to be friends, I thought. At least sort of friendly. Because it's hard, I think, for a teacher in school, like Junior high, where nobody cares, so, if you meet a person who is actually interested, like I was, and I really was - I wasn't the smartest or remembered the most, like I said, but - I was genuinely interested in things. I wanted to learn, right, I felt like I needed to comprehend a little about the universe, you know? I did. 'Cause it intrigues me. The way it works. Yeah. *(beat)* and I think a teacher can pick up on that. And he just responded to it . . . so, we started to sort 'a hang out a bit . . . just at school. The library, or looking at slides in the resource center. Lunchtimes. *(beat)*

I mean, I was thirteen, okay; it was nice to have somebody look at you and not say to pick up your socks . . . something like that. Let's face it; thirteen's a pretty bad age, right? *(pause)* He did give me a ride home, though. From school. He did do that. I mean, nothing, not a look on the outing, sits way away from me on the bus, but back at our building, see, he's responsible for us, and all the parents are there, this is a Friday, and my dad doesn't show. We go into the office, call his work, nothing at home, and he doesn't come. Half-hour goes by, nobody at school but us. Sitting there on the curb, waiting for my dad. Finally he says, my teacher, he said he'd run me home if I'd like that's what he said, "if you'd like that." *(beat)* in the car, like this was yesterday, I recall he had this woman singing on the tape player, real soft and painful, I remember, 'cause I had to ask who this was. I mean, this was not the Bee Bees and I'd never heard anything like it. So fragile-sounding, you know? First thing he'd said to me, I mean, practically, in five hours is "Billie Holiday." And he smiled, and he says, "She's all I ever listen to." And then, "you kind of remind me of her, you know? You always seem just a little bit sad. Smiling, but sad. I like that. . . *(beat)*

What did that mean? You know? Because, listen, you don't say stuff like that to a thirteen-year-old, okay? You just don't, uh-uh, 'cause she'll be yours for life. I mean it. if you do, she

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will be . . . *(Pause)* not in front of my house, but down from it, a block maybe, he pulls over, there's a florist shop and he parks in the little lot they have there . . . he kissed me. . . I really don't wanna, umm, elaborate too much on, well, you know, cover all the relationship stuff a whole lot, 'cause if you've talked to him you know it already, anyway, right? Maybe more than you want to . . . *(beat)*

We started seeing each other, you know, as much as a junior high school teacher and a thirteen-year-old can see each other. And I know what you're thinking, or have thought it to each other, laughing and stuff, that it's my own fault or that he was some type 'a molester, whatever, but you wouldn't really be true about that. We, umm . . . just liked each other. *(pause)* My fourteenth birthday . . . 's in March, he, umm, picked me up at the library, and we went driving. I asked where but he said, "It's a surprise," so I sat back the sun roof was up, it's a real nice day out, and just kind 'a drifted off to the sound of the wind rushing by. The wind and Billie Holiday singing sad on the back speakers . . . *(stops, gathering her thoughts).* When we got to Chicago, he drove straight to the lake, to this pier where he'd rented a boat for us, beautiful red speedboat, and God; it was so exciting for me! He just kept doing things like this, and there's a picnic basket and it was great, just great . . . to be out there, in the water, on this boat with him, it was just real lovely . . . *(beat)*

He gave me a bracelet, it was all wrapped up, in wax paper, inside my sandwich! Yeah, you believe that, he'd hollowed out my bread and put my present inside there, and I loved that, that was just cute . . . and I got, ahh, this beautiful, like, picture book of Greek stories, mostly of Euripides, 'cause, see, he felt Euripides was the most, what, "humanistic . . . had, like, the most humanity of the Greek writers. He said he was the one most at war with this . . . *(beat)* Still can't think of that word, but he was the guy who was really angry about the world being all messed up just because we happened to be mortals . . . anyhow, it had a bunch 'a nice drawings and he said I'd like it even more as I got older... *(beat)* I still have it. *(silence)*

I, umm . . . found out about the baby, that I was going to have one, in late April, the 23rd, I

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guess, and I didn't cry. You know, but sometimes you can go along, years even, and not feel like you're growing up at all, and then there's times when you age a ton, like, in a couple'a seconds. You know? So, I found out and went straight to his place, I mean, called first, but went there and we discussed it all. Talked a long time . . . *(beat)* we talked, like I said, and, you know, he seemed, and this caught me, 'cause I didn't know what he'd think, but he was all excited! Not yelling, and said he loved children, could think of nothing better than having a son or something. Said we'd have to be careful I mean, we both understood the situation - but I promised him I wouldn't tell anybody who the father was. I said I'd keep our secret . . . we made a pledge together, there on his sofa, and I kept it. *(beat)*

He told me that day, he said he had to go away for a couple weeks, just the end of summer, he was finishing up another of his degrees at Delphi, that's a university, and then we'd, you know, make some plans. *(beat)* That was hard, 'cause I was scared, I'm not gonna pretend I wasn't, but getting his degree was a big thing, and could help us, too, he said , , , and so we talked for awhile, and we kissed. God, you know for being this big guy, he was really gentle to me . . . *(beat)* Okay. Umm, what else? Ahh . . . when I found out he'd left his position at school - this was by a fluke, anyway, I was at the general office during the summer, bringing them a vaccination report on my brother, and the lady there, the secretary, said, "oh, I heard about your arts and sciences teacher at Gardner," my school, "we're sure sorry to lose him, aren't we?" I didn't hear much else, really, just that she said, "Well, I suppose they need good teachers in Phoenix as much as they do anywhere . . . " *(beat)*

But there's a bunch 'a crap you don't need to hear twice, and I don't want your sympathy, okay, I don't, so we'll skip the hardship stuff about when I did tell my family, and being pulled out 'a school, the move to my aunt's house . . . sound familiar? I told you before, or if I didn't, I meant to . . . this story's nothing special; really, practically the only part that's of any interest is that it happened to me . . . you know? *(beat)*

Anyways, Billie, that's my son, Billie, "William," whatever . . . was born. A beautiful boy. Just great, and although every mom goes off on that, he was. I mean it. He's great, and, umm, I

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give birth and a bunch'a years pass. Okay? I did finally make contact with his father, sent a couple letters, and he wrote me back right away, this was, ohh, maybe a year, eighteen months later and asked if I could understand. Not forgive . . . understand. *(beat)* I, ahh, let him know that our pact was still safe, and this wasn't, like, some money thing, I just wanted him to have, if he wouldn't mind so much, a sort 'a relationship with Billie, through the mail or whatever. I knew there was nothing for us, well, you know, not after that . . . but I'd send pictures and stuff, we ended up doing it through a postal box, and he got to know his son that way. That's how it happened. A few presents now and again, and he had a son, and the son's mother loved him, and kept the secret all while the father was away. *(long pause)*

The rest you know . . . on his fourteenth birthday, Billie and me, we rented a car - we were living in Utah by then, out with some Mormon relatives at that point - and we drove to Arizona to meet his father. We'd planned this, the two of us, by letter, and agreed it'd be just the one time . . . he was, umm, you know, married by this time, married and teaching in Phoenix. No children, though, isn't that funny? No kids 'cause his wife had a part of her uterus, I guess, some thing, that wouldn't work properly. I thought that was the only real sad part 'a all this - so, it'd just be this once, at a motel that he'd picked in town. One time when we'd all sit down and see each other. Again. At least, the two of us, again . . . *(beat)*

We met at the room. 's a terribly hot day, at least for December it was, 's how I remember it, anyway, and we were tired from the travel, but he was there and it was this big moment for Billie, 's all excited, and we even hugged, and it was in that second, as he leaned in to kiss my cheek, his head turned toward me and maybe it was just the light, the sun coming in the room, but I saw something there, there in his eyes . . . he loved this boy, all that he'd said to me years ago, it was true about kids. He loved 'em. But also . . . he was satisfied. I could see that, satisfaction on his face . . . because he'd gotten away with it all. That's what I saw, shining in his eyes, as he moved forward to kiss me. He'd beaten fate . . . and gotten away with it. *(beat)*

After dinner he said he wanted to see us again before we left. He had to run to school for

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about an hour, a science fair, I guess, but he'd be back. He promised he'd be right back. The last time I saw him, there at the door, he mentioned that word, that . . . umm, well, whatever, he said it and smiled, as he stepped out onto the balcony he smiled to me and whispered, "Maybe it's not our fault after all. I mean, we're just human, right?" *(pause).*

Billie was already in the bathroom and I could hear the water running. He was in his bath. God, he loved the tub! Since he was tiny, he loved it. So, I knew he was in there, the water filling up around him, and "lady day" - 's what he liked to call Billie Holiday, playing on his tape player. "Stormy weather." I, ahh, went into the room, the bathroom, and I could see him there, through a little opening in the liner he had pulled shut, eyes closed and the steam coming up.

He didn't really struggle, couldn't actually, the shock of it, I suppose, when the recorder first hit the water . . . there was really only a quick kind 'a snapping sound, like the pop of a flashbulb or whatnot, and then the softer sound of him, Billie, as he kicked a second or two in the water. I turned the taps off a little later . . . *(beat)*

After, I just sat there, on the linoleum, and watched him, lying in that cloudy pool of bath water. His eyes open and so still. *(pause)* “Adakia," that's the word. The word I was trying, you know, that's it. "The world out of balance." I knew it'd come to me, if I waited long enough. I was picked up in Vegas, at a restaurant, you're aware of that, though, obviously . . . and brought back here. And that's it. So, now you know. I mean, what you really wanted, anyway, right? Now you know . . . yes. I planned it, yes. But . . . maybe longer than you thought, huh? Lots longer . . . *(laughs to herself).* But I’ll tell you. Tell you what gets me through today, the next hour . . . it's him. *(pause)* I can almost see 'em, you know, I can, down there in Phoenix. Can't be consoled, right, the truth all spilled out now like it is, and all these tears running down, yelling up at the sky, these torrents of tears and screaming, the top of his lungs, calling up into the universe, "Why?! Why?!!" over and over. *(beat)* but you know what? In my fantasy, there's never an answer. Uh-uh. There never is . . .

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AWARD HISTORY

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